

Bruschetta- Ricotta Dip

FOR THE HONEY RICOTTA

15 ounces (425g) whole milk or double cream ricotta
1 tablespoon honey
Salt, to taste
Freshly ground black pepper, to taste

FOR THE BRUSCHETTA

1 large baguette
Extra-virgin olive oil, for brushing
Salt, to taste
Freshly ground black pepper, to taste
12 ounces (338g) cherry tomatoes, quartered
2 tablespoons aged balsamic vinegar
4 large fresh basil leaves, sliced or chopped

TIPS & TRICKS

The ricotta, toast, and tomato mixture can all be made several hours in advance and assembled when ready to serve. Store the ricotta and the tomato mixtures covered in the fridge, and the toast at room temperature.

We all love bruschetta—it's the ultimate celebration of amazing summer flavors with fresh tomatoes and basil, and it is, of course, delicious. The only thing is . . . it's a pain. You have to make all the individual crostini and top each one just so. And you only have a small window to do it because otherwise they'll get soggy and sad. So instead, I've taken all the classic components and piled them over honey-whipped ricotta for a layered dip. Serve it with toasted baguette slices as an appetizer, or enjoy it for dinner with a glass of wine. **SERVES 8**

MAKE THE HONEY RICOTTA: In a medium bowl, combine the ricotta and honey, then vigorously stir until well combined. Season to taste with salt and pepper. Spread the mixture over the bottom of a wide serving bowl and refrigerate until ready to serve the bruschetta.

MAKE THE BRUSCHETTA: Position an oven rack about 6 inches from the broiler. Preheat the broiler to high.

Slice the baguette into ½-inch-thick rounds and arrange them in a single layer on a large baking sheet. Brush each slice generously with olive oil and sprinkle with salt and pepper.

Set the bread under the broiler for 1 to 2 minutes, watching closely so that it doesn't burn, which it can do very quickly. Set aside to cool while you make the topping.

In a medium bowl, combine the tomatoes, balsamic vinegar, basil, and a good sprinkle of salt and pepper. Mix well.

Use a slotted spoon to scoop the mixture over the chilled honey ricotta and drizzle generously with olive oil. Serve with the toasted baguette slices on the side.

Variations

MAKE IT CANAPES: Spread the whipped ricotta over the baguette slices and top with the tomato mixture or halved grapes, olive oil, and herbs; supremed citrus; chopped olives—your imagination is the limit.

MAKE IT A PASTA MAIN: Stir the ricotta and tomato mixture into just-cooked pasta for a super-quick and delicious meal.

